before Muralitharan would. On that tour, both Saqlain and I, young, unbridled, creative, had our original tricks and techniques to counter the opposition: Down Under, Saqi and I were a proper duo.

I remember the first final, a low-scoring game, where we were chasing 180. I opened the innings with Inzamam and hit 53 off 54. Ian Bishop, Curtly Ambrose and Courtney Walsh were part of the Windies pace battery. It was the first time I was playing such an all-star bowling attack, that too on Australia's seamer-friendly pitches. Moreover, there was a lot of pressure on us in that game, and it had nothing to do with the Windies' ferocious bowling attack.

This new stage fright was self-inflicted. A day prior to that game, Saqlain and I had had a 'night out' (read party) with a senior player whom I won't name. But much to our surprise, this unnamed player spilled the beans about our evening to the skipper, Wasim Akram, who became livid on learning that we had 'broken curfew and stepped out'.

Here's the thing about Wasim Akram: he is a thorough gentleman. Every time he meets you, the first 90 seconds are nothing but an exchange of pleasantries. He will inquire about you, your family and your health. He is not someone who raises his voice, nor does he ever get straight to business.

But that day, on the morning of the first final, he really gave us an earful. Our only excuse was the late start to the game – it was a day-night match – and that the senior player had said it was okay to step out. But Wasim bhai didn't want to hear any of our excuses. He was firm and laid down the law: if we didn't perform that day, there would be no place for us in the team in the future. So, clearly, with the most well-known Windies attack in history glaring at me from down the pitch and Wasim's ultimatum at the back of my mind, it was crucial that I score well in that game. In some ways, it was a do-or-die situation for me.

After Wasim bhai's reprimand, Saqlain and I chatted and decided that we had to give our best. There was no way out. Saqlain did all right with his bowling. I did well with both the ball (3 for 33 in 10 overs) and the bat (53 off 54 balls, 8x4). That was also the day I fought off the myth around the West Indies pace attack – in Pakistan we call it the *kaali aandhi*, the black storm. Although a racial description, it's not meant as a racist comment and is fondly used in the Pakistan press.

Anyway, moral of the story: do not party with your teammates the night before a big match. If you do, make sure you kick some ass the next day and win. Wasim bhai's ultimatum stuck: from that day, both Saqlain and I stopped partying the night before a match. That didn't mean we stopped partying altogether. More on that in just a bit.

Since I mentioned that it's important to kick ass, I must share a related story. In that first final, I also caught and bowled Brian Lara. Yup. Brian Charles Lara TC, OCC, AM from Santa Cruz, Trinidad, caught and bowled by the nineteen-year-old Shahid Afridi from the streets of Gulshan-e-Iqbal, Karachi.

Lara was a bit of a myth and nightmare (particularly for bowlers) at the time. But we dealt with him in our own way. There was a hit Indian film song in those days, '*Koi jae to le aye*', that was quite popular in Pakistan too. We Pakistani players had made our own rendition of the item number which featured one of the hot favourite actors at the time, Mamta Kulkarni. At the chorus she would move to the words '*Maara re*', and we would sing something on the lines of '*Maara re, Lara ne mujh ko maara re* (I've been hit, oh I've been hit by Lara)', in the dressing room whenever we were playing the Windies. That's how awesome Lara was: he had inspired the